

tions like feel-good films, Google TV offers stronger curation. For repeated actor or title searches, Fire TV surfaces OTT availability better, while Google TV often falls back to general web results.

Now, since Vega OS is not Android, existing Android apps do not automatically work natively. Developers must port or rebuild apps for Vega. Currently, some apps are hosted on cloud servers, although I didn't notice any performance issues with this. But some apps may not be as feature-rich or have as many settings to tweak as their Android versions, like Plex was in my testing. And if you look up a niche app, you may not get it here, as the OS is rather new. But there are good signs, as only recently, two popular VPN apps, viz., NordVPN and IPVanish, joined the library.

However, one area where Vega OS is really limited compared to its Android counterpart is sideloading. Amazon has restricted installation from unknown sources, and this could matter to you if you used media-server apps like Jellyfin, game-streaming apps, any obscure IPTV app, or file managers like ES File Explorer before. Also, regular users can't access Developer Options.

PERFORMANCE

The new Fire TV Stick 4K Select runs on MediaTek's MT8698 MCM processor with Cortex-A55 cores up to 1.7GHz clock speed, a G310v2 GPU with up to 500MHz, 1GB LPDDR4 RAM, and 8GB storage. This one has a slower GPU and less RAM than the 4K Plus model. The RAM and ROM combination is the same as the Fire TV Stick HD. For wireless connectivity, you get a Wi-Fi 5 radio, which was fairly stable, but it is the same as the entry-level Fire TV Stick.

The 4K Select supports HDR10+ and Dolby Atmos passthrough. No Dolby Vision. Still, you can expect high-definition visuals and enhanced audio with compatible modern TVs and soundbars.



Largely in my testing, menus scrolled fine, and apps opened decently fast. But there was one instance when the Fire TV stopped responding, and I had to force-reboot it. Also, even though there were occasional stutters in navigation, none were to the point where they spoiled my experience. I also found the device ran mildly warm during my use. Well, it is winter in Delhi right now. But it matters, as a TV cabinet could trap heat.

Playback quality is good. 4K streams on Netflix and Prime Video lock in fine. HDR10+ offers colours and detail comparable to Dolby Vision content. I tested this on a Sony flagship OLED TV. All in all, the Fire TV Stick 4K Select offers an easily enjoyable viewing experience.

Motion handling is solid too. The Match Original Frame Rate setting works as intended, and you can clearly see it doing its job by preserving the creator's intent.

VERDICT

The Fire TV Stick 4K Select offers reliable 4K HDR playback, fast and direct results in voice searches, Dolby Atmos passthrough, familiar and functional software, and hardware performance suited to mainstream services. As its packaging reads, this Stick has the

essentials. The UI smoothness, motion handling, and app support should be agreeable enough for regular users.

There are limitations to consider, though, as a first-generation product. Vega OS is still new, and its app library is narrower than Android-based rivals. Sideloading is restricted, and some apps may not offer the same depth of features and options as their Android versions. The hardware also sits closer to the entry-level stick, with 1GB RAM, Wi-Fi 5, and no Dolby Vision. Occasional stutters and the need to manage limited storage are part of the experience.

Even with those gaps, the value is clear. For Rs 3,999, the Fire TV Stick 4K Select improves meaningfully on the HD stick and serves as a sensible upgrade for anyone who wants 4K without paying for the faster, more capable Fire TV Stick 4K Plus. If your needs are basic and your budget is firm, this is the most practical pick in Amazon's lineup. If you are upgrading from an older Fire TV Stick HD or a first-generation Fire TV Stick 4K, you will see a clear improvement in both responsiveness and stream quality. If you already own the Fire TV Stick 4K Plus, there is no reason to consider this model.

—G. S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Quad-core 1.7 GHz | Storage: 8 GB internal | Wifi: Wi-Fi 5 | Bluetooth: Bluetooth 5.0 and BLE | Ports: HDMI output, micro-USB for power | Voice support: Alexa Voice Remote included | Audio: HDMI pass-through of Dolby-encoded audio | Video Support: HDR10, HDR10+, HLG, H.265, H.264, VP9, AV1 | Output resolution: 2160p, 1080p and 720p up to 60 fps | Cloud Gaming: Xbox Game Pass

CONTACT

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